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The ruling YSRCP is dismissive of her challenge. "Whoever works against Jagan will be our opposition," says senior YSRCP leader and minister Peddireddy Ramachandra Reddy. Jagan's advisor (public affairs) Sajjala Ramakrishna Reddy spies a Naidu conspiracy in Sharmila joining the Congress. "It is not worthwhile to speak about a party (Congress) that got fewer votes than those polled in the NOTA category in the last election," asserts Ramakrishna Reddy. He points to signs of a coordinated TDP and Congress (and even BJP) game plan to defeat Jagan. The 'signs' include a recent meeting between Naidu and Karnataka deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar at the Bengaluru airport and Sharmila and her husband travelling to Delhi to join the Congress on BJP Rajya Sabha member C.M. Ramesh's private jet!

What is certain is that politics in Andhra Pradesh is in a state of flux. "Jagan is on a sticky wicket," says Vageeshan. "He may not be in any adversarial relationship with the BJP, but the party does not trust him. The TDP and ally Jana Sena Party (JSP) are still unclear about going to the polls with the BJP, which is not a force to reckon with in Andhra Pradesh." And while Sharmila could dent Jagan's fortunes by claiming for the Congress the YSR legacy and weaning leaders and cadres from the YSRCP, she is unlikely to emerge as a giant-killer.

WHERE DID IT ALL BEGIN?

With YSR's untimely death in 2009, of course. That black swan event led to a power tussle within the Congress in the state as Jagan, backed by some staunch loyalists, laid claim to his father's legacy, and the Congress refused to endorse him as YSR's successor. The struggle ended with the formation of YSRCP, which Jagan announced in December 2010.

The rift widened with the UPA government ordering a CBI probe in 2011 into the alleged accumulation of illegal wealth by Jagan during his father's tenure. Following his arrest on May 27, 2012, sister Sharmila set out on a 3,112 km *padayatra* in October that year, on the lines of her father's iconic march, Praja Prasthanam (People's March) almost a decade earlier. While Jagan was in jail, it was Sharmila and mother Y.S. Vijayamma who handled party affairs.

SHARMILA CONTINUED BATTING FOR THE YSRCP, ALWAYS TAKING THE FIGHT TO NAIDU. BUT WITHIN A YEAR OF JAGAN GETTING OUT OF JAIL, THE CAMARADERIE BETWEEN THE SIBLINGS WAS OVER

Jagan walked out on bail 16 months later and took the reins of the YSRCP, but could not, despite the party's best efforts, prevent the Naidu-led TDP from capturing power in the truncated Andhra Pradesh in 2014. Through it all, Sharmila continued batting for the YSRCP, with her Odarpu yatra in 2016 and the 'Bye Bye Babu' slogans against the TDP supremo. The sustained campaign paid off in 2019, with YSRCP winning 151 of the 175 assembly seats.

It took less than a year, though, for the sibling camaraderie to fall apart, as Sharmila did not find a place in the party for which she had worked for a decade. There were reports of disputes over sharing family assets too. All this perhaps prompted her to launch the YSR Telangana Party (YSRTP) in 2021 on her father's birth anniversary, July 8, and embark on a *padayatra* across Telangana, leaving Andhra to her brother. But before long, she saw her plans being curtailed by the then Telangana CM, KCR. She was literally stopped in her tracks, as the police put her under 'house arrest'.

Sharmila was also the secret CBI witness in the murder case of her uncle, the former minister Y.S. Vivekananda Reddy, in March 2019. She claimed that the attempt to ensure her cousin Y.S. Avinash Reddy got the YSRCP ticket to the Kadapa Lok Sabha seat led to Vivekananda Reddy's brutal murder in the midst of electioneering. Jagan backed Avinash when the issue came up in the legislative assembly, and trashed the TDP allegations against him. The YSRCP has since been accusing Naidu of trying to divide the YSR family.

Discussions between Sharmila and the Congress had been on since May, say sources, but party leaders in Telangana opposed it. The Congress high command had then itself suggested that she join the party but focus her energies on Andhra. Talks were at a stalemate till, on the eve of the Telangana nominations, Sharmila announced that her YSRTP would sit out the elections to prevent "a split in the Congress vote". From then on, it was only a matter of time before Sharmila committed. Now the only question is whether she can bring her *padayatra*-level energies to bear and revive a moribund state Congress. ■